

Singapore–Cambridge GCE O Level English Language (Syllabus 1184) Paper 2 — Comprehension Practice Paper 9

Time allowed: 1 hour 50 minutes

Total marks for Sections B and C: 45

Instructions to candidates

- Answer **all** questions in Sections B and C.
- The number of marks is given in brackets [] at the end of each question.
- Answer in **complete sentences** where instructed.
- For the summary in Section C, write **no more than 80 words**, not counting the words given to help you begin.

Section B — Text 3 (Narrative) [20 marks]

Text 3: The narrator recounts her attempt to swim across an eight-kilometre channel of open water.

1

The water at six in the morning was the colour of cold tea, and roughly the same temperature as a slap. I stood on the slipway with my arms folded across my ribs, watching the support kayak bob ten metres out, and tried to remember why this had once seemed a reasonable idea. The far shore, I knew, was somewhere out there beyond the haze — eight kilometres of nothing in particular, separating my life on this side from a small concrete jetty on the other. My coach gave me the nod. I waded in to my waist, gasped once, and then, because there was nothing else for it, I dived.

2

The cold went through me the way a wire goes through clay. For a few seconds I could not believe that my body would consent to keep working in such a substance. Then, slowly, the rhythm I had drilled for a year took over: arm, arm, breathe; arm, arm, breathe. The shoreline behind me began to shrink. The kayak slid into position at my left shoulder, a steady wooden shadow with a small, calm woman in it, and I settled, for the first half hour, into the curious peace of having only one thing to do.

3

A long swim, I had been told, is half a conversation with yourself. By the second kilometre I understood what my coach had meant. There is no scenery to distract you. There is no music. There is only the underside of your own goggles, the small thunder of your breathing inside your skull, and the cold pressing patiently at every seam of your wetsuit. I counted strokes for a while. I named the muscles in my shoulder. I tried, briefly, to recite the periodic table, and was annoyed to find that I could not get past argon.

4

Somewhere in the middle of the channel, where the water turned a darker, less forgiving green, the doubt came. It did not arrive as a single thought, but as a slow leak. My right shoulder had begun to ache in a way that felt less like fatigue and more like warning. The far shore, when I lifted my head to sight it,

did not appear to have moved at all. The near shore, when I glanced back, had become an embarrassing blue smudge. I was, for a long minute, exactly halfway to nowhere, and the sea beneath me was, by my coach's estimate, sixty metres deep.

5

The kayak drifted closer. The woman in it — Mei, who had paddled beside me through every training swim — did not ask whether I was all right, which was kind of her, because I would have lied. She held up a small bottle of warm sports drink on a stick. I took it, swallowed two mouthfuls, and gave it back. She said, very quietly, “Three thousand more. You have already done five.” She did not say **you can do it**. She did not say **be brave**. She said, instead, an arithmetic fact, and the arithmetic fact was, for whatever reason, exactly what I needed to hear.

6

I have read, in the years since, that endurance athletes sometimes describe a strange clarity that arrives when the body is suffering. I had always assumed this was a flourish — the sort of thing people say in interviews. In the sixth kilometre, however, something of the kind did happen to me. The cold stopped being an enemy and became, simply, the medium I was moving through. My breathing fell into a long, four-stroke pattern that seemed, ridiculously, to require no effort. I began to notice small things: the way a gull tilted on the wind above me, the way a piece of weed turned slowly in the bow-wave of the kayak. The inner voice that had been bargaining with me went quiet. Something else, harder to name, kept swimming.

7

The last kilometre was the longest. The shore, perversely, seems to retreat the closer one gets to it: a low, mocking trick of perspective. My fingers had gone the colour of old wax. Mei tapped her paddle against the side of the kayak, twice, the agreed signal for **five hundred metres**. I did not lift my head to check. I trusted her. The arm, arm, breathe became a kind of prayer that I had not asked to recite.

8

When my hand finally struck the concrete of the far jetty, I did not feel triumph. I felt, instead, a small and rather puzzled gratitude — to my arms, which had not stopped; to Mei, who had not coddled me; and to the water itself, which had, on this particular morning, decided to let me through. I climbed out shaking. Someone wrapped a foil blanket around me. I looked back across the eight kilometres I had just travelled, and I could not, quite honestly, see them. The haze had closed. The far shore — which was now this shore — had become, again, an idea.

From Paragraph 1

1. The narrator describes the water as “roughly the same temperature as a slap.” Explain, in your own words, what this comparison suggests about the water and her first impression of it. [2]

2. Give **two** details from Paragraph 1 that suggest the narrator is feeling reluctant or apprehensive before she enters the water. [2]

From Paragraph 2

3. The narrator writes that “the cold went through me the way a wire goes through clay.” Explain how this comparison helps the reader understand what the cold felt like. [2]

From Paragraph 3

4. In Paragraph 3, the narrator says that “a long swim... is half a conversation with yourself.” What does this phrase suggest about the **mental**, rather than physical, demands of long-distance swimming? [2]

From Paragraph 4

5. The narrator says the doubt “did not arrive as a single thought, but as a slow leak.”
- (a) Explain what this comparison suggests about how the doubt entered her mind. [1]
- (b) Give **one** other detail from Paragraph 4 that shows the doubt was growing. [1]

From Paragraph 5

6. The kayaker, Mei, says only “Three thousand more. You have already done five.” Explain how the language used in this paragraph makes Mei seem like a thoughtful and effective companion. Support your answer with **two** details from Paragraph 5. [3]

From Paragraph 6

7. The narrator writes that “the cold stopped being an enemy and became, simply, the medium I was moving through.” Explain what this change suggests about her state of mind in the sixth kilometre. [2]
8. The narrator says her inner voice “had been bargaining with me.” What does the word **bargaining** suggest about the nature of her earlier doubts? [1]

From Paragraph 7

9. Give **one** piece of evidence from Paragraph 7 that shows the narrator was physically struggling near the end of the swim. [1]

From Paragraph 8

10. The narrator says she felt “a small and rather puzzled gratitude.” What does this tell us about how she had expected to feel at the moment of finishing, and how she actually felt? [2]
11. What is the **tone** of the final sentence of the text? [1]

Section C — Text 4 (Non-narrative) [25 marks]

Text 4: A feature article on the cultural significance of street food in Southeast Asia and beyond.

1

A bowl of noodles eaten standing on a Bangkok pavement is, on the face of it, a transaction lasting five minutes and costing rather less than a cup of coffee. To treat it as only that, however, is to miss almost everything that matters. Across Southeast Asia — and increasingly across the world — street food is recognised as something far more interesting than cheap fuel. It is a living archive of migration, a public stage for neighbourhood life, and, for millions of people, a daily, edible answer to the question of who they are. A meal sold from a metal cart, the argument goes, can carry as much heritage as a temple.

2

The historical case is hard to dispute. Singapore's hawker culture, inscribed on the UNESCO Representative List of the Intangible Cultural Heritage of Humanity in 2020, traces its origins to itinerant cooks of the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries — Hokkien, Teochew, Tamil, Malay — who set up portable stoves at street corners because they could not afford shopfronts. The flavours of modern Singapore — laksa, satay, char kway teow, roti prata — are therefore not merely **popular**; they are the audible accents of a particular history of poverty, migration, and ingenious improvisation. Similar stories can be told of Penang, Bangkok, Hanoi, and Manila. The recipe was, in each case, born of necessity, and only later promoted to the status of national symbol.

3

The social significance, meanwhile, is daily and visible. A hawker centre or pavement stall is one of the few remaining public spaces where the office clerk, the bus driver, the schoolchild, and the retiree share not only the same room but, often, the same long communal table. A Goldman Sachs analyst will queue behind a delivery rider for the same plate of chicken rice, and neither will be charged more than the other. In cities increasingly segmented by income, this is a quietly radical fact. Sociologists have begun, belatedly, to call such venues “third places” — neither home nor workplace — that **bind a society together**.

4

And yet the story is not a comfortable one. As cities grow wealthier, street food faces a peculiar new threat: prosperity. In Bangkok, repeated crackdowns by city authorities have, since 2017, cleared vendors from many of the lanes where they had cooked for decades, in the name of pavement order and tourist photography. In Singapore, the average age of hawkers is now in the late fifties, and the children of stallholders, having paid for university with their parents' woks, are largely unwilling to inherit the eighteen-hour days and the unrelenting heat. Hawker centres are full at lunch, but their kitchens are quietly emptying.

5

There is also the matter of commercialisation. The very recognition that street food now enjoys — the Michelin stars, the food-tour buses, the Netflix series — has begun to alter the thing it celebrates. A stall that once charged three dollars for a bowl of noodles may, after a glowing review, charge eight; the locals who once queued at it now go elsewhere, and a different clientele, with cameras, replaces them. The flavour of the noodles may not have changed, but the **meaning** of eating them has. What was once neighbourhood food has, in some quarters, become a tourist experience priced accordingly.

6

Hygiene regulation is the third pressure, and the most awkward to discuss honestly. Modern food-safety rules — refrigeration standards, licensed kitchens, separation of raw and cooked surfaces — exist for good and obvious reasons; nobody seriously wishes to return to a world in which a fried-noodle stall could give

a hundred people food poisoning in one evening. Yet the same regulations, applied without flexibility, can extinguish small operators who simply cannot afford a stainless-steel kitchen. The difficult question facing many cities is therefore not **whether** to regulate, but **how** to regulate without destroying the very informality that makes street food what it is.

7

Can street food, then, survive prosperity at all? Optimists point to encouraging signs: hawker apprenticeship schemes in Singapore, vendor associations in Bangkok that bargain collectively with the authorities, and a younger generation of cooks who treat a hawker stall as a serious culinary apprenticeship rather than a fallback. Pessimists point to rising rents, ageing cooks, sanitised “food halls” that imitate the look of street food without its substance, and a steady drift towards Instagrammable versions of dishes their grandmothers would not recognise. The honest answer is probably that street food will survive, but only where a society chooses, deliberately, to protect it — through subsidy, through training, through the unglamorous work of writing regulations with a light hand. A culture is not preserved by accident. It is preserved, in the end, by people who decide that it is worth the trouble.

From Paragraph 1

12. The writer says that a meal sold from a metal cart “can carry as much heritage as a temple.” Explain, in your own words, what this comparison suggests about the importance of street food. [2]

From Paragraph 2

13. According to Paragraph 2, give **two** facts about the origins of Singapore’s hawker culture. [2]

14. The writer says that famous dishes such as laksa and roti prata are “the audible accents of a particular history of poverty, migration, and ingenious improvisation.” Explain, in your own words, what this phrase tells us about how these dishes came to exist. [2]

From Paragraph 3

15. The writer describes the hawker centre as a place where “neither will be charged more than the other.” Why does the writer think this fact is “quietly radical” in modern cities? [2]

16. The writer uses inverted commas around the phrase “**third places**”. Explain why the writer chooses to put inverted commas around this phrase. [1]

From Paragraph 4

17. The writer says that street food now faces a “peculiar new threat: prosperity.” Why is this threat described as **peculiar**? [2]

18. Give **two** details from Paragraph 4 that show that the future of hawker food is uncertain. [2]

From Paragraph 5

19. The writer says that the “**meaning** of eating” street food has changed, even though the flavour has not. Explain, in your own words, what the writer means by this. [2]

From Paragraph 6

20. What is the writer’s **tone** in the sentence beginning “Hygiene regulation is the third pressure, and the most awkward to discuss honestly”? [1]

From Paragraph 7

21. The writer ends the text by saying that “a culture is not preserved by accident. It is preserved, in the end, by people who decide that it is worth the trouble.” Explain what is **effective** about ending the text with these two short sentences. [2]

22. Summary question [6 marks for content, 7 marks for use of own words and style]

Using your own words as far as possible, summarise **the cultural value of street food and the threats it faces today**, as outlined in the text.

Use **only** material from **Paragraphs 2 to 6** of Text 4.

Your summary must be in **continuous writing** (not note form). It must **not** be longer than **80 words** (not counting the words given to help you begin).

Begin your summary as follows:

Street food is culturally valuable because it ...

— END OF PAPER —